



SQL OF THE DAY

mind the tie at five

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StrataScratch · #10048

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THE PROBLEM

Find the top 5 businesses with the most reviews.
Return the business name and total review count.

rank carefully...

Medium · PostgreSQL

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THE SOLUTION

```
WITH business_rank AS (  
    SELECT business_id,  
           name,  
           SUM(review_count) AS review_count,  
           RANK() OVER (  
               ORDER BY SUM(review_count) DESC  
           ) AS rnk  
    FROM yelp_business  
    GROUP BY business_id, name  
)  
SELECT name, review_count  
FROM business_rank  
WHERE rnk <= 5;
```





HOW IT WORKS

AGGREGATE

SUM(review_count) grouped by business gives total reviews per business.

RANK THE TOTALS

RANK() OVER (ORDER BY total DESC). Two tied at rank 3 push the next to rank 5, not 4.

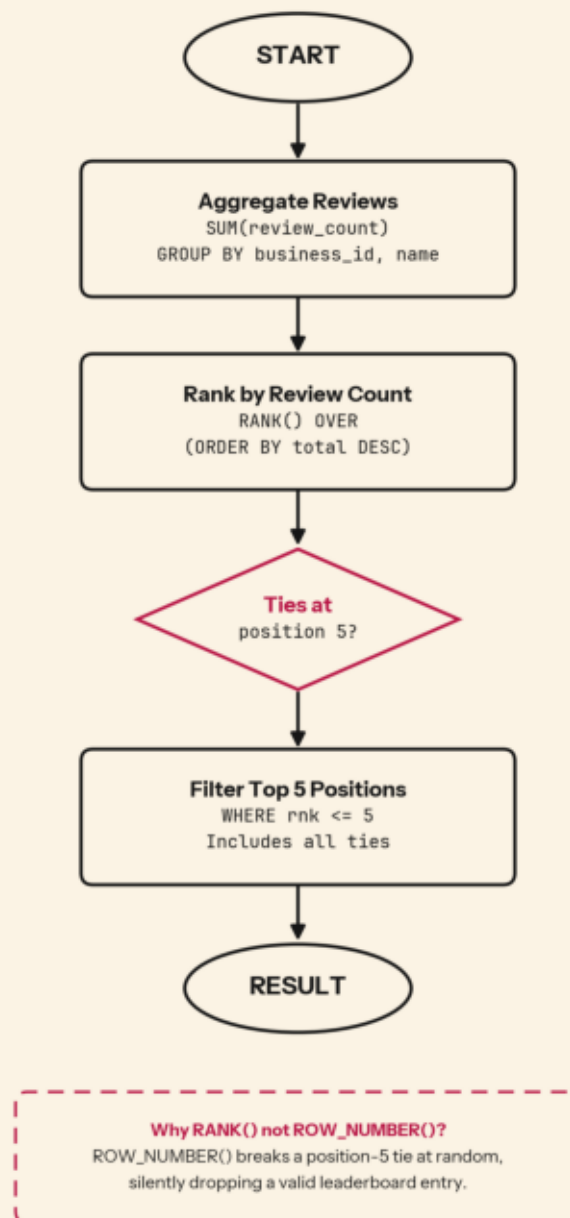
FILTER TOP 5

WHERE rnk <= 5 keeps everyone in the top 5 positions, ties included.





THE LOGIC





WHY IT MATTERS

01

Fair leaderboards

If two businesses tie for 5th, dropping one makes a business that earned its spot vanish from a ranking customers see.

02

Spend follows the list

Featured placement and partnership outreach aim at this top 5, so a truncated leaderboard points budget at the wrong accounts.

03

Competitive signal

A business tracking its own rank needs to know when it is tied with a rival, not just its raw position.





KEY TAKEAWAYS

- 1 `ROW_NUMBER()` on a tied leaderboard is a silent bug: clean output, missing entries.
- 2 `RANK()` is the right default for competitive top-N. Tied rows share a position and `rnk <= 5` catches all.
- 3 `DENSE_RANK()` can return more rows than expected when ties sit above the cutoff.

follow for more SQL problems

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